true of client-servicing roles that dominated sectors such as IT and ITeS, consulting, marketing, accounting and law. Thirty-year-old Delhi-based consulting professional Karan Sharma (*name changed*) shares how he would log in sharply at 9 am to work with colleagues in their Hong Kong headquarters until 3 pm. "Inevitably, every day, we would miss lunch or even drinking water, as there was always a rush to finish deliverables." Afterward, he would continue working on reports for the next day, often finishing around midnight. "Logging out at 12 or 1 am was normal," he says. That's a 16-hour workday.

Target-based roles, such as those in sales and investment banking, are among the most challenging. Employees in these roles face constant pressure to meet targets, frequently travel for client meetings, and experience even greater stress during economic slowdowns. Sometimes employees also complain about toxic environments, where managers vent their own frustrations on their juniors, are unresponsive or use harsh language. Little wonder that a joint report by the Confederation of Indian Industry and the digital healthcare platform MediBuddy released this July found that a staggering 62 per cent of Indian workers in the 1,000

companies they surveyed experienced work-related stress and burnout, triple the global average of 20 per cent. "We are animal bodies," says Dharmaraj, "but we are treating ourselves like machines."

The burnout is the highest at the middle management level, says Pallavi Jha, chairperson and managing director of Dale Carnegie Training India. They are the link between the top management's strategy and execution, and not only have to upskill with new technology and ensure that the vision of the top management is executed well, but also have to keep up the motivation and morale of their team members. This does not mean the top management is immune to anxiety. "Technology is disrupting business models, the overall environment is not only competitive but also uncertain, there is a lot of focus on profitability. Leaders not only have to run businesses but also ensure they stay relevant for the next 2-3 decades," says Mishra of CIEL HR.

> **"Long working hours mean the company isn't investing enough in human capital, and there aren't enough people to share the workload"**
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> **- PALLAVI JHA,** *CMD, Dale Carnegie Training India*

BURNOUT AMONG THE YOUNG

No one is feeling the pressure like Gen Z and the millennials (those born between 1981 and 1995). Fuelled by rising ambitions and the culture of instant gratification, they are becoming managers at a younger age. This was borne out by a survey by industry body Nasscom, which found out that millennials and Gen Z account for over 90 per cent of the workforce in tech companies. Not only are they moving up fast, but moving jobs equally fast too. This rapid movement of talent, says Krishnamurthy Shankar, former Group HR head at Infosys,

HOW STRESS AFFECTS THE MIND & BODY

MENTAL EFFECTS

- Anxiety
- Depression
- Memory lapse
- Loss in creativity and initiative
- Low self-esteem
- Underconfidence
- Anger/ Irritability

PHYSICAL EFFECTS

- Headaches/ Migraines
- Sleeplessness
- Heart palpitations
- Muscle/ Joint pain
- Skin eruptions
- Indigestion/ Loss of appetite
- Fatigue

